The Congress Plan

Though the Gandhians and some of the business and propertied representatives were opposed to commit the party to centralised state planning (including Mahatma Gandhi)[8], it was on the initiative[9] of the INC president Subhash C. Bose that the National Planning Committee (NPC) was set up in October 1938 under the chairmanship of J.L. Nehru to work out concrete programmes for development encompassing all major areas of the economy. Basically, the NPC was set up in a conference of the Ministers of Industries of the Congress-ruled States (though other states were also invited to participate) where M. Visvesvaraya, J.R.D. Tata, G.D. Birla and Lala Sri Ram and many others including academicians, technocrats, provincial civil servants, trade unionists, socialists and communists etc. were also invited. The 15-member NPC with 29 sub-committees and a total of 350 members produced 29 volumes of recommendations.[10] The work of the committee was interrupted when the Second World War broke out and in the wake of the Quit India Movement many of its members including the chairman were arrested, and between 1940 and 1945 the Committee had only a nominal existence. Though the final report of the NPC could only be published in 1949, many developments related to planning took place during the Interim Government upto 1946.

"A series of valuable reports were published which brought together the constructive thinking done by the committee and the sub-committees and the material collected in the course of their work. The importance of the NPC lies not so much in these reports as in the wide interest it created throughout the country for co-ordinated planning as the only means of bringing about a rapid increase in the standards of living and its emphasis on the need for bringing fundamental changes in the social and economic structure."[11]

Some of the important developments after the NPC was set up which prepared a foundation for the coordinated planning in independent India are given below:

(i) ***Post War Reconstruction Committee:*** Early in June 1941, the Government of India formed (on popular demand) a Post-War